particularly in East and Southeast Asia. Fourth, it kept its nuclear option open. Finally, it contemplated a rapprochement with China. Not all these efforts were successful, and some led to friction with Washington, but Delhi pursued all these options—in addition to the US one—over the next few years.

The Soviet Option

The Soviet Union continued to aid India. Between 1955 and 1968, it provided $1.4 billion worth of credit to India. It was also India's second-largest trading partner. On the military side, Indian defense officials considered the Soviet Union to be more willing than the US to help build India's indigenous defense production capacity and its navy. In May 1968, Moscow would also finalize an agreement to sell India one hundred Sukhoi aircraft.[175]

Nevertheless, this relationship was not without problems. The Indian government resented Soviet criticism, including of India's ties to the US, its economic performance, and the composition of the Indian cabinet. There were also problems related to bilateral trade, as well as a number of Soviet industrial projects. And the defense ministry complained that Moscow was delaying the supply of military spare parts.[176]

What really stung, however, were Soviet-Pakistan relations. While Sino-Soviet relations remained strained, Moscow's relationship with Islamabad kept getting closer. The Soviet Union signed economic assistance agreements with Pakistan in 1966, 1967, and 1968.[177] In fall 1967, Indian officials reacted negatively to the Soviet suggestion that India, as the larger country and given the domestic situation in Pakistan, should be more accommodating to Pakistan—Haksar saw this as Soviet "pandering" to Pakistan.[178] Then, in September 1967, Moscow welcomed Ayub Khan, who subsequently indicated that Soviet leaders had promised him economic aid until 1975.[179] In spring 1968, Kosygin became the first Soviet premier to visit Pakistan, where he pledged economic assistance, as well as the construction of a nuclear power plant.[180]

But it was Ayub's rumored discussions about Soviet arms supply that caused the most concern in India. There were rumors that Kosygin had agreed to sell military equipment. There were also reports of potential Soviet aid for the construction of a naval base in Pakistan—the quid pro